Does old equal best?

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Satan is ancient, very ancient; does that make him good? Are all old people good, just because they are old? Recent generations no longer read books, but those of us who still do know that a book that is used wears out. A book that is used cannot possibly last for 1,500 years. Papyrus is a fragile, vulnerable material that cannot stand much use. All of the known NT MSS from the first three centuries are written on papyrus. If they survived, they were not used. Why were they not used?

I suggest two reasons: 1) They were produced in Egypt where any Greek speaking communities were dying out; by the year 200 there were very few, so there was no one to use them. 2) They were so bad that it was psychologically impossible to use them; this can be demonstrated objectively. The references for everything that I will state below can be found in any of the last six editions of my book, *God Has Preserved His Text!*

I will begin with P^{66}, generally dated around 200 and it is one of the earliest of considerable size (it contains most of John). This MS has an average of two mistakes every verse, which is incredibly bad. It would be psychologically impossible to use it for devotional reading or study. Its mistakes usually involve a syllable, which means that the copyist did not know Greek—when copying a language that you know, you copy phrase by phrase, or at the very least, word by word; never syllable by syllable. The copyist was not competent to do the job, as demonstrated by his sloppy work.

P^{46} is also generally dated around 200 and contains a significant amount of Paul's letters. Gunther Zuntz did a thorough evaluation of this MS and wrote: "the scribe who wrote the papyrus did his work very badly". Other scholars have given similar evaluations.

The date for P^{75} has been given as around 220. It contains most of Luke and John. It is not as bad as P^{66}, but has many mistakes. From the pattern of its mistakes, the copyist copied letter by letter (even worse than P^{66}), which means that the copyist did not know Greek. The copyist was not competent to do the job, as demonstrated by his poor work.

P^{45} has generally been dated around 250. It contains parts of all four Gospels and Acts, but is actually shorter than P^{66}. This copyist did know Greek, because although his work is full of alterations, they almost all make sense. In other words, the copyist deliberately changed the text. So it is not an honest copy; it is a fabricated copy.

P^{47} is also generally dated around 250. It contains about half of Revelation. Here is what Kurt Aland wrote about this MS: “We need not mention that the oldest MS does not necessarily have the best text. P^{47} is by far the oldest of the manuscripts containing the almost full text of the Apocalypse, but it is certainly not the best”. In fact, it is one of the worst.

P^{72} is generally dated around 300 and contains 1 & 2 Peter and Jude. Tommy Wasserman collated over 500 MSS for Jude. P^{72} is by far the oldest MS that we have for Jude, but it is also by far the worst, with over two mistakes per verse (like P^{66}). It has almost twice as many mistakes as the second worst MS.

Those are the six largest papyrus MSS from the first three centuries; all of the rest are fragmentary. It is objectively correct to say that they are old, but to say that they are good would be objectively false. None the less, modern textual critics do say that they are good, ignoring the objective evidence. Those MSS survived because they were not used and were buried in the desert sands of Egypt.

Some versions contain footnotes that refer to “the earliest and best” MSS, by which they usually mean Codices Vaticanus and Sinaiticus. I will now consider the major Codices from the IV and V centuries.

Codex B, GA 03 (Vaticanus), is often dated around 325. It has the complete NT except for the Pastoral Epistles and Revelation. Westcott and Hort regarded it to be the very best of all extant MSS, and many subsequent scholars have agreed with them, to this day. However, strange to relate, Hort himself wrote that the scribe of B “reached by no means a high standard of accuracy”!! True enough; it is full of omissions, and not a few careless repetitions of words and phrases. Ernest C. Colwell attempted to construct an archetype of the ‘Alexandrian’ text for the first chapter of Mark, based on a majority vote of representative MSS. Just in that one chapter, 45 verses, Codex B was wrong 34 times! Codex B does not belong to any line of transmission. It disagrees with Codex Aleph over 3,000 times just in the four Gospels (which number does <u>not</u> include different spellings of the same word). One or the other has to be wrong in those places. It is written on fine vellum, very expensive, which means that it was not prepared for public reading in church meetings. This is also evidenced in that it is one of five MSS written in three columns; not good for public reading. It has no ‘children’; no one wanted to copy it. It does not belong to any line of transmission; it is a fabricated copy.

Codex Aleph, GA 01 (Sinaiticus), is often dated around 350. It is basically a complete NT. Westcott and Hort regarded it to be the second best of all extant MSS. But it is so bad that over ten people down through the centuries tried to correct its many mistakes. It disagrees with Codex B on overage in every verse of the four Gospels. It is the only known MS that is written in four columns, which means that it was certainly not prepared for public reading. It does not belong to

any line of transmission. It has no 'children'; no one wanted to copy it. It is not an honest copy of any known exemplar; it is 'fabricated'.

Codex C, GA 04 (Ephraemi Rescriptus), has been dated to the V century. It contains the whole NT with lacunae. It is a palimpsest, which means that the NT text was scraped off the leather and something else was written in its place. It was 'recycled'. Evidently someone considered that its text was so bad that it was not worth saving. It also has an 'inconvenient' number of so-called 'Byzantine' readings, but it has its own mixture. It does not belong to any line of transmission; it is a fabricated copy.

Codex D, GA 05 (Bezae), has been dated to the V century. It contains the four Gospels and Acts. It is the main representative of the so-called 'Western' text, which means that it is different from all the others. In Acts it is incredibly bad. It does not belong to any line of transmission; it is a fabricated copy.

Someone could reasonably ask, "Where did the scholars get the idea that those MSS are good?" The analogy of a stream coming from a spring has been used: the closer to the source, the purer the water should be. But scholars of all persuasions have recognized that most 'corruption' of the NT text occurred during the second century, earlier than the dates of all the MSS that I have described. So how can anyone tell how much of that corruption is in those MSS? However, the real problem lies in the area of presupposition.

Textual criticism of any text presupposes that the original wording of that text has been lost, in the sense that no one knows what it might have been. No one does textual criticism on today's newspaper or last week's magazine. No one even does it on the first edition (1611) of the KJV, since a copy still exists. Most practitioners of NT textual criticism use some form of eclecticism, and eclecticism is based on the following presuppositions: 1) the NT writings are not inspired (had they been inspired they would have been preserved); 2) the early Christians did not recognize them as inspired; 3) therefore they did not concern themselves to protect and preserve those writings; 4) therefore the original wording was lost in the sense that no one knew for sure what it might have been; 5) it was only when the superstition and credulity of the Christians had elevated those writings to the condition of 'Scripture' (around 200 AD) that they began to concern themselves with protection and preservation, only by then it was too late; 6) therefore there was no normal transmission of the NT writings until after the third century, and there is no objective way to recover the original wording. All of them are false.

Notice that eclecticism excludes the supernatural from its model. In reality, the idea that oldest equals best is a stronghold of Satan in their minds. Such a stronghold locks them into the falsehood, and since the only escape is supernatural, those who reject the supernatural condemn themselves to stay

with the falsehood. I have written extensively on this subject and will not go into it here.